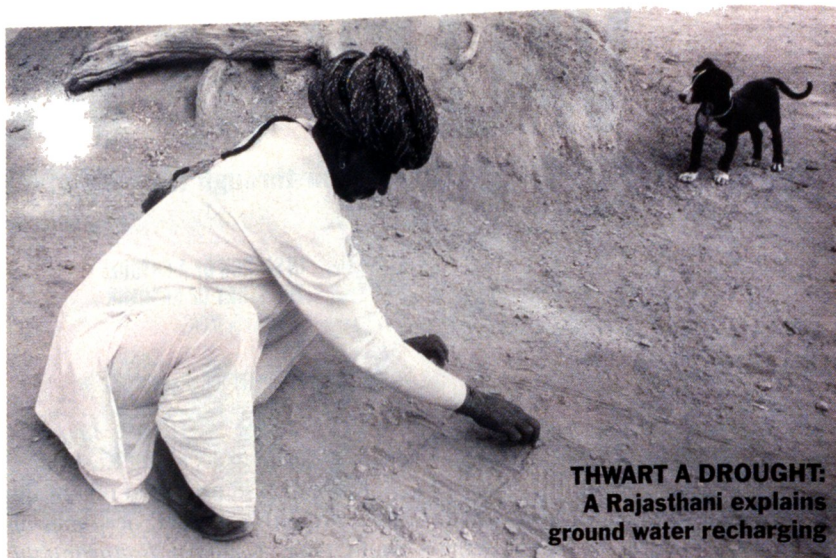


plex political, social and economic developments in Kashmir from 1931, the year the Muslim Conference was established. It is rich in detail, and elegant in style. And yet Devadas's lack of training comes to the fore as he makes sweeping generalisations that would make any serious academic squirm. Take this: "Kashmir struggled vigorously to become a modern nation state but failed to develop a viable model. Kashmiris were hobbled by internecine suspicions as well as the culture of guile and intrigue that grew through centuries of colonial oppression. An even greater weakness is that the aspiration remained stuck in a mindset of contemptuous superiority, one that not only kept it divided but prompted it to look for a future premised on the oppression of other." And yet this book, despite an occasional bloomer, is full of valuable insights and is rich in anecdotal detail. A must-read for all Kashmiri aficionados

A Mission in Kashmir focuses on one date: October 27, 1947, "the day that India accepted Kashmir's accession to India—the day that Pakistani tribesmen ransacked St Joseph's convent and hospital at Baramulla." A date which "is privileged by the high politics of the Kashmir dispute but explored and discussed through the stories of those who were caught up in the events more than those who were directing them". The horrifying as well as the fascinating account of the tribal invasion of Kashmir and the attack on St Joseph's mission constitutes the bulk of the book. The account is brilliant and moving, and is first-rate by the standards of both a journalist and a social historian. Whitehead is also responsible for creating an oral archive on Kashmir at the School of Oriental and African Studies in London.

Both the authors have demonstrated that there is still a lot to be written about Kashmir. Ordinary stories that have remained unrecorded can often reveal much more than official documents or UN resolutions. The recovery of these accounts may not only contribute to generating a richer social history of the land and its people that does not privilege just a few, but may eventually also help in the resolution of Kashmir's problems. ■



THWART A DROUGHT:
A Rajasthani explains
ground water recharging

Humble Heroism

A photo-journalist's tribute to inspirational people who have braved the odds to do their good deeds tirelessly and for little reward



UNSUNG
by ANITA PRATAP AND MAHESH BHAT
Mahesh Bhat Publishing
Price: NOT LISTED
Pages: 97

■ **By Dilip Bobb**

This is an unusual book in many ways. It has been sponsored by corporates like Mahindra, Infosys and Vodafone and published by one of the authors, photo-journalist Mahesh Bhat. Another journalist, Anita Pratap, gets top billing but writes only a brief introduction. I suspect the reason is she rewrote much of the copy attributed to Bhat. This is, however, his book, his idealism, his photographs and his reportage on India's unsung heroes, ordinary people who have sacrificed much to change the lives of the people around them by overcoming huge odds: powerful opposition, lack of resources and personal tragedy.

Despite the NGO-type focus, this slim volume is an important testament. While it is essentially Bhat's personal tribute to inspirational people he has stumbled across during his photo-assignments, it brings into focus India's real heroes who do their good deeds tirelessly and for little reward. There is Chewang Norphel from Ladakh who, without formal training,

has been building artificial glaciers near villages to help his people overcome the region's greatest enemy and the cause of its poverty—aridity. There is also George Pulikuthiyil, the Catholic priest who took up law in order to help poor innocent people who could not defend themselves in court. Equally inspirational is the work of Bangalore's Hasnath Mansur, who has overcome fearsome odds in order to educate Muslim women and make them aware of their rights.

There are many others with similar stories, similar sacrifices, not the least of them being Subhashini Mistry, a woman who had nothing but rose from the ashes after seeing her husband die in hospital due to the callousness of doctors who refused to treat him because he was penniless. She suffered every possible misfortune but battled on to bring up her four children and eventually build a hospital where the poor could be treated. Each of the stories is so stirring, so rare, so powerful and so moving that Bhat deserves our gratitude for bringing them to the public domain. Their collective humility and their humanity are in such stark contrast to the celebrity-led Page 3 focus of our times that it should either inspire or shame others into emulating their example or supporting their unsung efforts. ■